



When controversial businesses meet dialogic communication: Insights from public relations practitioners in the oil and gas industry

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ABSTRACT

This study investigated how public relations practitioners understand and practice dialogic communication in the controversial oil and gas industry. Guided by theoretical works of dialogic theory of public relations, the dialogic ladder, and negative spaces of dialogue, in-depth interviews were conducted with 21 practitioners who held public relations/communication positions serving the oil and gas industry in Canada. The findings suggest some points of alignment between practitioners' understanding of dialogic public relations and the related theoretical orientation. Practitioners reported predominantly using an interpersonal approach for shallow dialogue followed by mediated and procedural approaches with different stakeholders in practice. Interviewees also shared the unique challenges they face in practicing dialogic communication due to the controversies surrounding the industry. Theoretical and practical implications are discussed.

1. Introduction

Kent and Taylor (1998) argued that public relations should be understood from a dialogic perspective. Theoretically, this perspective emphasizes organizations' deep involvement, active participation in open communication, and willingness to take risks to reach mutually beneficial relationships between organizations and stakeholders (Capizzo, 2018; Lane, 2020; Taylor & Kent, 2014). Hence, it is considered more ethical (Kent & Taylor, 2002; Pearson, 1991). Practically, dialogic communication can result in positive outcomes for organizations, such as increased trust and credibility with stakeholders, greater stakeholder engagement, and improved understanding between parties (Men et al., 2018; Wang & Yang, 2020; Yang et al., 2015). This perspective includes five principles that highlight interactive, public-oriented communication in building online-mediated relationships with publics. More recently, dialogic communication, which is highly relational (Kent & Taylor, 2002), has become one of the main paradigms in public relations research (Ao & Huang, 2020; Chen et al., 2020; Kent & Taylor, 2002). It has been studied in various public relations contexts, such as crisis communication (Cheng, 2020; Romenti, et al., 2014; Wang, 2016), corporate social responsibility (Illia et al., 2017; Uysal, 2018), citizen activism (Kang et al., 2018), and employee engagement (Dhanesh,

2017), as well as across different cultures (Cheng, 2020; Thelen et al., 2020).

Most studies in this area have focused on developing the theoretical grounds and explaining how dialogue can be incorporated into public relations practices. However, less is known about how the relevant concepts and theories are perceived by public relations practitioners (Paquette et al., 2015). The dialogic theory of public relations, which advocates for applying dialogue in organizational contexts (Kent & Taylor, 2002), has been criticized for being too idealistic to be incorporated into daily practice due to the imbalanced and unpredictable results, internal power dynamics, lack of supportive policies, and lack of resources and time (Ihlen & Levenshus, 2017; Lane & Barlett, 2016). In addition, scholars have claimed that dialogue is context-specific (Ao & Huang, 2020) and influenced by systematic constraints at the macro level (Ihlen & Levenshus, 2017), which adds another layer of complexity when applying the theory to practice. In general, how the tensions from these constraints shape the process of dialogic communication in public relations has not been sufficiently acknowledged in the literature, especially from a practitioner's perspective.

To fill these gaps, this study focuses on the controversial Canadian oil and gas (O&G) industry as a unique context to investigate how public relations practitioners understand and practice dialogic communication.

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The O&G industry in Canada serves as a unique context to revisit and develop the theory and practice of dialogic public relations for two reasons. First, Canadian society is highly community-based in that a significant focus of public relations in Canada is on community relationships (Likely, 2009). Thus, this context provides the ideal environment for developing dialogic communication between organizations and publics compared to marketing-orientated environments such as public relations in the U.S. (Kelleher & Males, 2020). Second, although the O&G industry is a pillar industry in Canada that provides many job opportunities and considerable economic income (Statistics Canada, 2020), the industry has experienced controversies and contentious confrontations due to the complexity of the business, the large profit margin, and most importantly, the environmental risks and impacts (O'Hara, 2005). Historically, dialogue has been used to mediate the interactions between conflicting groups in various contexts from city councils (Pearce & Pearce, 2003) to warring nations (Toledano, 2017). Thus, it is hoped that a dialogic approach to public relations can improve the relationship between these companies and their publics.

This study interviewed 21 public relations practitioners working for Canadian O&G industry. We had two research goals. First, we explored how communicators (i.e., practitioners) in the O&G industry understand and practice dialogic communication to cultivate relationships with key publics. Their answers can reveal the convergence and divergence between theory and practice in a controversial Canadian business context and thus can contribute to the development of the dialogic theory of public relations (Kent & Taylor, 2002). Second, this study aimed to identify the factors that prevent practitioners' dialogic efforts. The results of the interviews provide important insights that allow us to recommend effective strategies for this controversial industry. In particular, the recommendations are based on what has worked, what has not worked, and what can be done in the future through the lens of dialogic communication. Thus, the findings facilitate the application of dialogic public relations in practice.

2. Literature review

2.1. Oil and gas industry and public relations

Controversial businesses refer to "products, services, or concepts that for reasons of delicacy, decency, morality, or even fear elicit reactions of distaste, disgust, offense, or outrage when mentioned or when openly presented" (Wilson & West, 1981, p. 92). An industry is considered controversial if its products, concepts, or services are perceived as inherently "morally corrupt," "unethical," or "offensive" (De Colle & York, 2009), or it is issue-riddled, with controversy about the negative social and environmental impact of the operation (Jo & Na, 2012). The O&G industry is considered issue-riddled, given the social and environmental consequences of using the products or daily operations. Consequences include global warming from using the products, ocean pollution due to oil spills, and air and water quality deterioration around petroleum refineries (Perera, 2017). This study specifically focuses on the O&G industry in Canada because it has several characteristics that distinguish it from other controversial businesses, which provides a unique opportunity to deepen our understanding of dialogic communication.

Most O&G companies in Canada are upstream and midstream companies. In other words, they mostly focus on searching for, recovering, producing, collecting, and transporting crude oil and natural gas instead of selling natural gas products from crude oil (Government of Canada, 2020). This operation model requires that companies develop and maintain good relationships with key stakeholders such as landowners and local communities to ensure smooth daily operations. This relation-centered focus of the industry's public relations provides the perfect opportunity for a dialogic approach to promoting public relations. The O&G industry is also a pillar industry in Canada, contributing \$105 billion to the nation's GDP (Statistics Canada, 2020) and supporting

about 400,000 jobs across the country (CAPP, 2020). However, like other controversial industries, this industry has severely suffered from public disapproval and criticism (Rand, 2014). To sustain this large-scale industry and continue supporting the nation's economy and job market, it must seek legitimacy and approval, if not support, from publics.

The need for effective public relations, which is about helping organizations to better understand and function within its specific physical and societal environment (Heath, 2010), is urgent and dialogic communication is one aspect of the solution. O&G companies recognize the industry's negative social and environmental impacts and are thus transitioning from a traditional O&G business model to a cleaner energy business model (Beck, et al., 2021). The success of this transition again requires recognition, approval, and support from publics, which can be facilitated through good relationships between the companies and publics. The unique challenges of this industry provide opportunities for dialogic and relational-orientated public relations.

Very few studies have explored public relations theory and practice in the O&G industry, and most of those that have examined O&G companies focused on corporate social responsibility (CSR) practices. These studies have provided relevant insights into this industry's public relations practices and have laid the foundation for the current study. For example, Chowdhury et al. (2019) found that employee- and community-related CSR activities are key value drivers for O&G companies. Thus, they have called for strategic planning of CSR activities that can be achieved through public relations planning. Kirat (2015) focused on Qatar O&G companies and concluded that they had been involved in limited CSR activities, and there is a gap between awareness and practice. Du, Edward, and Vieira (2012) analyzed CSR communication on the websites of six O&G companies and concluded that these companies need to exhibit more transparency and be active in two-way and constructive dialogue with stakeholders. Collectively, these studies suggest that O&G companies need to be more strategic and active in communicating with their stakeholders. Thus, scholars have called for more research on this industry. To extend this line of research and answer the call, the current study explores public relations in the O&G industry from a dialogic theory of public relations perspective.

2.2. Dialogic theory of public relations

The term "dialogue" has been defined differently in various disciplines. Pearson (1989, 1990, and 1991) introduced this concept as the pioneer scholar in public relations (Kent & Lane, 2021; Lane, 2020). In his view, dialogue is ethically superior to other forms of communication in public relations as it uses respectful and truthful two-way communication to achieve a mutually beneficial relationship between organizations and stakeholders (Pearson, 1991). Following his lead, other scholars (e.g., Capizzo, 2018; Fitzpatrick & Gauthier, 2001; Kent & Taylor, 2002; Stenmann & Zerfab, 1993) began to develop the concept of dialogue and dialogic communication in the public relations context. Although definitions abound (e.g., Kent & Taylor, 1998, 2002), dialogic communication is broadly defined as an orientation, focused on deep engagement, being present in communication, and being open to risk to achieve relational-oriented goals leading to mutual benefits between organizations and stakeholders (Capizzo, 2018; Lane, 2020; Taylor & Kent, 2014).

As a research topic, the dialogic approach has attracted considerable attention from public relations scholars due to its ethical superiority and relational orientation (Chen et al., 2020; Morehouse & Saffer, 2018; Theunissen & Wan Noordin, 2012). Kent and Taylor's (2002) work provides a relatively clear framework for understanding this construct. Drawing on literature from different disciplines, including philosophy and psychology, they proposed five features/principles of a dialogic approach to public relations (mutuality, propinquity, empathy, risk, and commitment) and discussed how these features might be used in a public relations context.

Mutuality refers to an acknowledgment of the inextricably intertwined nature of an organization and publics that is manifested as an organization-public relationship. Organizations should have the spirit of mutual equality and collaborate with stakeholders in dialogic exchange. *Propinquity* refers to the process of rhetorical exchange that is temporal and spontaneous. This process is created through three avenues: 1) immediacy of presence indicates that communication about issues must occur before, not after, decisions have been made; 2) temporal flow emphasizes that communication is relational and seeks to construct a future for all parties; and 3) engagement refers to participants who are willing to give their whole selves to dialogic communication. *Empathy* refers to the supportive and trustworthy atmosphere of dialogue, which can be achieved through 1) supportiveness that encourages participants to communicate and facilitates participation; 2) communal orientation that develops public relations as a tool to build community; and 3) confirmation that acknowledges the voices of others. *Risks* refers to the willingness to communicate with publics on their own terms. Risk may lead to vulnerability and unanticipated consequences due to open information sharing and exchange. However, relationships are also built through vulnerability despite unanticipated consequences. Risk also involves recognizing strange otherness, especially different ideas, thoughts, and beliefs. The last feature is *commitment*, which refers to the degree to which organizations are dedicated to dialogic communication. The three dimensions of this feature are genuineness, commitment to conversation, and commitment to interpretation.

Kent and Taylor (2002) argued that dialogue is both a concept and a practical strategy. Thus, they provided three practical strategies to incorporate dialogue into practice. The first strategy is to build interpersonal relationships, which implies that all organizational members, including employees and leaders, are comfortable engaging in dialogic communication leading to relationship building. Some skills are needed to facilitate this strategy, including listening, empathy, long-term orientation, and seeking opposing ideas. The second strategy is to build mediated dialogic relationships, which means engaging in and facilitating dialogic interactions through mass media channels, including websites, magazines, newspapers, and social media. The last strategy is a procedural approach to realize dialogic communication that emphasizes the process. This strategy encourages organizations to create a mechanism to facilitate dialogue.

Although Kent and Taylor's (2002) work provides a solid foundation for dialogic public relations theory, they also acknowledged that the complex and multifaceted nature of dialogic communication requires more research to advance theoretical development and explore the practicality of this approach in public relations practice. Kent and Taylor (2014) also developed their own theory by connecting dialogue to engagement. They argued that engagement is a part of dialogic communication and can guide the process of interactions, thus creating social capital. Chen et al. (2020) also combined Chinese traditional Taiji culture (tai chi) with dialogic theory. They proposed a Taiji model of public relations that illustrates both positive and negative aspects of contemporary public relations in China. Recently, Dutta and Elers (2020) also argued that indigeneity needs to be developed within the dialogue framework in public relations and that dialogue can be a powerful communication tool with indigenous communities.

2.3. Dialogue vs. two-way communication in public relations

Some scholars have contended that the concept of dialogue is often uncritically equated with two-way communication (Theunissen & Noordin, 2012), or what is called dialogue-in-name-only (D-I-N-O), a less rigorous form of dialogue (Kent & Theunissen, 2016). Since 2000, scholars have presented diverse perspectives on the construct of dialogue in public relations research (Lane, 2018; 2020), with one view treating dialogue as a universal label for any two-way (symmetrical or asymmetrical) communication (e.g., Avidar, 2017; Gesualdi, 2019). Another view is that dialogue is a form of communication characterized

by specific features such as the five principles developed by Kent and Taylor (2002). This divergence has impeded the development of the theory (Theunissen & Wan Noordin, 2012), as it has created confusion about the theoretical foundation of dialogue and thus impacted empirical studies. If there had been consensus on the theoretical foundation in those empirical studies, they could have potentially contributed to theoretical development.

Scholars have suggested different solutions to reconcile this theoretical tension around dialogue and two-way communication. In particular, Lane's (2020) dialogic ladder has emerged as a promising framework. In this dialogic ladder image, different forms of communication relevant to dialogue are organized in a ladder, with the lowest rung being simple two-way communication, ascending to the highest rung: true dialogue. The highest rung is characterized by five features: mutuality, propinquity, empathy, risk, and commitment (Kent & Taylor, 2002). In between, there is two-way communication with interactions and responses, and shallow dialogue (Davidson, 2016), which has one or more of the five features but not all of them. Each form of communication is a precursor to achieving the next rung on the ladder (Lane, 2020). All other forms (rungs) of communication are considered D-I-N-O before reaching the highest rung of true dialogue (Kent & Theunissen, 2016).

This theoretical framework encapsulates the relevant concepts in the current dialogic public relations literature (i.e., D-I-N-O, two-way communication, and dialogue's five features/principles). This concept also captures the delicate relations and tensions among these concepts using the ladder framework, indicating a progression where simple two-way communication is the starting point and the highest rung—true dialogue—is the ultimate goal. This framework enables researchers and practitioners to recognize the distinctions and characteristics of various forms of communication in relation to true dialogue while exploring and unpacking dialogue construct to facilitate theoretical development (Lane, 2020). Therefore, the current study adopts this dialogic ladder as the main analytical framework.

2.4. Practicality of dialogic public relations

The criticism of dialogic public relations also centers on the (im) practicality of this approach. True dialogue, which demonstrates the five features suggested by Kent and Taylor (2002), is often regarded as "a normative ideal" (Lane, 2020, p.3) that is too idealized to be practical (Chen et al., 2020; Kent & Lane, 2021). Ganesh and Zoller (2012) explicated the positions on dialogue in activism fueled with conflicts and tensions, suggesting that dialogue can be consensual, co-opted, or multivocal, depending on the empowerment of activists. However, public relations scholars and practitioners should be cautious about pursuing consensus-oriented dialogue that risks the exploitation of the powerless in seemingly symmetrical communication (Ganesh & Zoller, 2012). An examination of the empirical studies exploring how dialogue has been used in practice has revealed that most studies have examined the so-called dialogic communication (D-I-N-O) activities and assumed that two-way communication/talk is, indeed, dialogue (Kent & Lane, 2021). Thus, these studies have consequently produced questionable results. Most of these studies analyzed organizations' social media communication (Kent & Lane, 2021) to examine the extent to which public relations activities on these platforms reflect the so-called dialogic nature of dialogue (see Ao & Huang, 2020 and Morehouse & Saffer, 2018 for systematic reviews). In addition, few studies have surveyed stakeholders such as employees (e.g., Ruck et al., 2017). These studies lack practitioners' voices even though practitioners are the agents who practice various forms of communication, which could include dialogic communication for public relations purposes.

Recent work has begun to document the application of dialogue in practice from a practitioner's perspective. Two known in-depth interview studies (Lane, 2018; Lane & Barlett, 2016) invited professionals to share their experiences and practices at work, and both concluded that

true dialogue did not occur, nor did practitioners truly understand what it is. Despite the disappointing results, more studies focusing on the practitioners' perspective are still needed to 1) determine the general relevance of these research findings, and 2) allow academics to delve more deeply into each principle of true dialogue and how it can be used in practice (Lane, 2018; Lane & Bartlett, 2016). To address this gap, the current study uses a similar research approach but extends the study sample to practitioners in the O&G industry in Canada. We ask the following research questions related to the five features of true dialogue (Kent & Taylor, 2002) and the dialogic ladder framework (Lane, 2020):

RQ1:. How do practitioners working for O&G companies understand and define dialogic public relations and where does their perception of dialogue sit on the dialogic ladder?

RQ2:. What strategies do professionals use to practice dialogic public relations, and what features of true dialogue are demonstrated in their practices?

2.5. Challenges to practice dialogic public relations

Although true dialogue, at the highest rung of the ladder, is regarded as ethically superior, it should be noted that it is not "a panacea for public relations" (Kent & Lane, 2021). Both theoretical (Kent & Lane, 2021; Kent & Theunissen, 2016; Lane, 2020) and empirical works (Lane, 2018; Lane & Bartlett, 2016) have identified challenges to practicing dialogic communication in public relations. Kent and Taylor (2002) highlighted the risks associated with unanticipated outcomes of true dialogue and identified these risks as the main challenge. Kent and Lane's (2020) recent theoretical study further identified eight types of negative spaces where true dialogue does not occur, including situations when communication is instrumental, when communication is persuasive, when facts are at stake, when there is no trust or respect when there is a power issue, when there is no ability/willingness to change, and when the focus is on information instead of experience. Similarly, two empirical studies (Lane, 2018; Lane & Bartlett, 2016) concluded that it is challenging, if not impossible, to reach the true dialogue rung in practice due to practical constraints such as the organizational culture, limited time, and communicators' pre-existing attitudes of dialogic parties. Practitioners also lack education and training about dialogic communication (Lane, 2018; Lane & Bartlett, 2016). To add to this line of research, we focus on the challenges of practicing dialogic communication by incorporating the realities of practitioners' daily experiences and asking:

RQ3:. What are the perceived challenges of practicing dialogic public relations?

3. Method

To answer the research questions, this study employed semi-structured (Merriam, 2009), in-depth interviews to provide detailed information (Lindlof & Taylor, 2011) about practitioners' understanding of dialogic public relations and their day-to-day practices. Two pilot interviews were conducted prior to the formal interviews to ensure the clarity and completeness of the interview protocol. Participants were recruited through a newsletter of a Canadian public relations professional association and the researchers' personal networks. The research team conducted 21 online interviews with Canadian practitioners working in public relations/communication departments of O&G companies or working in agencies serving the industry. The interviews were conducted synchronously through Google Meet, an online voice-over internet protocol (VoIP) technology similar to Zoom and Skype. Google Meet has technological constraints, which could cause participants to be reluctant to engage in the conversation and may limit the researchers' ability to capture nonverbal and emotional cues that would be as rich as in face-to-face meetings (Gray et al., 2020). However,

others have argued that VoIP technologies are reliable and useful research tools given their rich user interactive functions, cost-effectiveness, and time and space flexibility (Archibald et al., 2019; Gray et al., 2020). Thus, Google Meet was the best choice for conducting interviews, given both the advantages and disadvantages of this technology and to comply with the restricted COVID-19 research protocol imposed by the university at that time. We stopped recruiting new participants after data saturation was reached (Glaser & Strauss, 1967), when no new information emerged from the interviews (Hennink & Kaiser, 2020). Participants were asked to share their thoughts on their understanding and interpretation of dialogic public relations and to share examples and stories about their practice of dialogic communication in their work. Interviews lasted about 40–60 min with an average of 53.75 min. All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed using otter.ai, a professional automated transcription software.

Of the 21 participants, 10 were male and 11 were female. Participants held the following positions pertaining to public relations and communication in the O&G industry: entry-level positions (3), advisor-level positions (6), mid-management level positions (3), senior-management level positions (5), and executive-level positions (4). Nineteen participants worked as in-house practitioners, and two worked in agencies serving this industry. Over half of the participants ($n = 11$) worked in large companies (more than 500 employees), about a quarter ($n = 6$) were employed in small companies (under 100 employees), and the rest worked in medium-sized companies (100–500 employees). On average, participants had 12 years of experience working in the O&G industry (ranging from half a year to more than 30 years) and had held the current position for 2.5 years (ranging from half a year to six years).

Before data analysis, the transcripts, totaling 341 single-spaced pages, were cross-checked with the audio recordings to ensure the accuracy and readability of the automated transcription. Data were then analyzed for themes related to the three research questions using thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006). First, each researcher independently read through all the transcripts multiple times to perform manual coding based on a theoretical framework of dialogic public relations and what emerged naturally from the data. Then, the researchers discussed and compared their coding decisions until a consensus was reached. Based on the agreed-upon coding results, two researchers worked together to generate themes around the codes. After this round of analysis, the two researchers revisited the transcripts to compare the themes with the data to ensure no data were missed. The final themes were then identified.

4. Results

The participants provided comprehensive and detailed information about their understanding and practice of dialogic public relations in the O&G industry in Canada. The following sections present the findings and representative quotes from participants to demonstrate these findings.

4.1. Defining dialogic public relations

To answer RQ1, participants described their understanding of dialogic public relations in their own words. Both statements and keywords were used to describe their understanding of the concepts. Three major themes emerged from their answers, which somewhat overlapped with Kent and Taylor's (2002) five features.

4.2. Dialogue as a two-way street

The majority of the participants acknowledged that dialogic public relations is a two-way process that requires input from stakeholders. Many participants emphasized the importance of "feedback," "engagement," and a "listen-and-respond" process. One participant indicated that between "listening and responding to your key stakeholders, the listening part is the most important." He emphasized that it was "not just

listening but seeking to understand what the issues are and looking for ways to resolve them” (Charlie). Practitioners strongly rejected the idea of one-way communication being effective. One of the participants stressed, “If you are the only one to talk or talking, you are lecturing; you are not in dialogue” (Liam). This theme demonstrates the mutuality feature of dialogue as participants acknowledged the inter-dependency between the organization and stakeholders. However, the spirit of mutual equality or seeking collaboration was not clearly stated. Participants highlighted that the organizations were seeking feedback and “resolving” the issues, but the stakeholders’ role in this consultation and engagement process seemed to be passive rather than equal.

4.3. Dialogue as a multi-way street

Some participants believed that understanding “different viewpoints” is essential for dialogic relationships with a broad group of stakeholders. They described dialogic public relations as “a multi-way street,” which means that communicators need to understand different viewpoints, especially opposing opinions. One participant defined dialogic public relations as follows:

It’s engagement, it’s discourse, it’s trading of ideas and thoughts and feelings and perspectives and values. So, it’s a two-way street; sometimes a multi-way street. You need to manage a whole variety of interests, and let everybody be heard and understood, and then try to work together to come to a joint solution. So, dialogues are always two ways or many ways. (Robert).

Most importantly, under this theme, participants stressed the importance of understanding “a variety of interests” especially “opinions of the other side,” which reflects the controversial nature of the O&G industry. Another participant described this controversy:

People that are in this (O&G) industry aren’t inherently against the environment or not environmentalists, and just like environmentalist, (they) aren’t necessarily people that are against the industry. I think it’s just important to engage in meaningful discussion and honest discussion and be open to the opinions of the other side. (Tom).

This theme reflects some aspects of the empathy feature of true dialogue. Participants expressed some support for stakeholders, allowing them to express their point of view, especially the ones with opposing views (e.g., environmentalists).

4.4. Transparency

Several participants mentioned transparency, which means being open about what their companies and the industry are doing. One participant contended, “I think it’s critical that we are communicating transparently and allowing people to see inside of an energy company and what it looks like and the kind of things that we’re focused on” (Luna). Some participants also emphasized that transparency is especially important during times of crisis, when “something goes wrong.”

A few participants touched on being vulnerable when discussing being transparent. They believed that being vulnerable means not only sharing what the company or the industry is doing but also sharing what they have not done well. One participant explained that vulnerability involves sharing what the company has learned from the past: [Table 1](#).

We’re also getting to be, you know, a little bit more comfortable with risk—that’s not the right word. But vulnerability. And so, you know, to sort of share that we don’t have the answer, or we’re working towards something, or we tried something, and we had some learning from it (Herbert).

The commitment feature was demonstrated under this theme as

Table 1

Background Information of Participants.

ID	Name	Gender	Position
1	Liam	Male	Mid-management
2	Charlie	Male	Senior-management
3	William	Male	Executive-level
4	Sybil	Female	Entry-level
5	Henry	Male	Executive level
6	Ivy	Female	Senior-management
7	Aria	Female	Entry-level
8	Daisy	Female	Advisor-level
9	Edith	Female	Senior-management
10	Gwen	Female	Mid-management
11	Luna	Female	Entry-Level
12	Everly	Female	Advisor-level
13	Tom	Male	Advisor-level
14	Mia	Female	Senior-management
15	Robert	Male	Senior-management
16	Atticus	Male	Executive-level
17	Patrick	Male	Executive-level
18	Herbert	Male	Advisor-level
19	Nora	Female	Advisor-level
20	Mary	Female	Mid-management
21	Richard	Male	Advisor-level

participants wanted to be honest with publics. However, it should be noted that many participants stated that the motive behind this honesty was to “educate” publics about the industry rather than to build a mutually beneficial relationship, which violated the relational orientation of dialogic public relations. It is also worth noting that the industry did not embrace transparency in practice, as one participant commented: “Some oil and gas companies are still the same, or they still don’t want to; they would rather say nothing” (Henry).

The three themes that emerged from the data only partially demonstrated three out of five features of true dialogue. In [Lane’s \(2020\)](#) dialogic ladder, the lowest rung is simple two-way communication, ascending to the highest rung: true dialogue, which is characterized by five features of mutuality, propinquity, empathy, risk, and commitment ([Kent & Taylor, 2002](#)). In between, there is two-way communication with interactions and responses, and shallow dialogue ([Davidson, 2016](#)), which has one or more of the five features but not all of them. Based on this dialogic ladder, we concluded that participants’ understanding, and perception remain at the lower rung of shallow dialogue (i.e., demonstrating one or more of the five features, but not all of them). No participant discussed the feature of risk (unanticipated consequences) or propinquity (the process of rhetorical exchange that is temporal and spontaneous).

4.5. Dialogic public relations in practice

[Kent and Taylor \(2002\)](#) noted that dialogue is both a concept and a practical strategy. After sharing their understanding of the concept, participants were invited to discuss various strategies they used to manage relationships with different stakeholder groups in a dialogic manner. Most participants organized their strategies according to different stakeholder groups strategically. However, whether genuine dialogue can be strategically tailored should be considered, as public relations affects how publics conceptualize environmental problems ([Aronczyk & Espinoza, 2021](#)), which is a key focus of public relations activities in the O&G industry. [Kent and Taylor’s \(2002\)](#) three approaches (i.e., interpersonal, mediated, and procedural) were incorporated into the practices to manage the four major stakeholder groups, although the interpersonal approach was the most used.

4.6. “Neighbors”

Almost all participants mentioned individual landowners and communities as one of the most important stakeholder groups. Some

companies referred to this group as “neighbors” since this group of stakeholders is always within geographical proximity of the companies’ operational sites. This echoes Hallahan’s (2004) argument that community should serve as the foundation for public relations practice. Companies mainly used an interpersonal approach to manage the relationships with this group. For example, participants emphasized the importance of organizational leaders’ engagement in conversations with this stakeholder group. They also mentioned specific skills companies needed to practice dialogic communication and enhance interpersonal dialogic communication, such as listening, empathy, and soliciting opinions. In addition, participants listed strategies to support this interpersonal approach to dialogic communication with “neighbors,” including face-to-face site visits, town hall meetings, and phone calls.

One participant shared examples of an interpersonal approach:

An environmental stakeholder person actually does kitchen table visits. We have, like, 23 neighbors that are close by. So, she did kitchen table visits before COVID. We also do a town hall every year which was an open house. We weren’t regulated by the government to do that. We just chose to do our annual town hall every year because it allowed us to sit down and have a chat with people. We would actually serve like a buffet meal, so people would come [sit with people] they’d know, and go around to those people that they wanted to see. We usually have about 20 representatives in the room as well as some of the key people. And so, we would sit down, you know, have a meal. (Mary).

The goal of using an interpersonal approach to dialogic communication with neighbors is to build ongoing personal relationships, which helps public relations practitioners understand neighbors’ needs at an early stage. One participant explained the purpose:

The focus was really about visiting the sites, especially for say the managers or the executives to build those relationships with them (landowners), usually face to face. And then it was also an opportunity for them (managers and executives) to go into those communities and see some needs. (Edith).

A few participants also mentioned using a mediated approach to manage relationships with communities, such as through social media (mainly Facebook), newsletters, mailings, and local community newspapers. However, participants considered these types of mediated communication as one-way communication that only served as information dissemination rather than dialogue.

Although participants described that the goal of their interactions with neighbors was relationship-oriented, most of the communication with this stakeholder group was not dialogic. Mutuality and empathy were partially demonstrated in examples, with participants clearly indicating that neighbors’ opinions and needs were solicited and heard. However, it seems that the organizations took control of the engagement as neighbors were only heard during organizational events or visits. There was no mention about what mechanism was implemented for neighbors to initiate communication on their own terms.

4.7. Investors and shareholders

Investors and shareholders were the second most often mentioned stakeholder group. An interpersonal strategy also was the main approach used to practice dialogic communication with this group. For interpersonal approach, many participants explained that the communication team and executives usually went to conferences and trade shows to meet investors in person. One participant explained, “We’ll go to a bank conference, so we could present to the investment community. They can ask us, ‘What are you doing with ESG?’ We can tell them, we can have that dialogue. And it’s good” (Liam).

Some companies also established an organizational system (procedural approach) for dialogue. Participants discussed different dialogic organization systems for shareholders, such as conversation opportunities and quarterly or annual meetings. For example, one participant noted that executives of the company were “used to having people come and talk to them face to face. Usually some of the stakeholders or shareholders would come directly to the office and ask to speak to our CEO” (Nora).

With investors/shareholders, the most salient feature was commitment. It is worth noting that because this group of stakeholders holds a relatively equal position of power in the dialogue, thus they seem to be receiving more sophisticated dialogic treatment. Participants clearly showed that their organizations were available to communicate on various occasions, such as at conferences and annual meetings. However, this commitment may not be true dialogue. It may have only been two-way communication (interaction and response), as there was a specific desired outcome behind the communication activities, such as encouraging investment. One participant commented, “So if you’re not there telling them that you are (being socially responsible), they won’t invest in you” (Patrick). Some participants also described a spirit of mutual equality to some extent, stating that their organizations gave partial control of the communication to the shareholders and let them initiate the communication on their own terms (e.g., visiting the CEO’s office).

4.8. Employees

All of the participants agreed that employees were the most important internal stakeholders, and the interpersonal approach was critical to manage this relationship. One key theme in managing this relationship was to build confidence in employees so they would be comfortable engaging in dialogue about their job and their company. Many participants mentioned town hall meetings with employees as an effective tactic. One participant explained that, “town hall meetings on a regular basis gives employees an opportunity to ask questions and be heard and get answers in real time” (Daisy). During these meetings, executives’ willingness to engage with employees and their interpersonal communication skills played a key role. One participant commented on their new CEO’s communication approach during town hall meetings, which really resonated with the employees:

It was just really refreshing to hear where he (CEO) came from, and where his values stand, and that he’s also very vocal about his focus on his employees, mental health, and [what] he was prior to becoming the CEO. He spoke out about advocating throughout COVID, about taking time off, and the resources that we have for it. So he’s always performed a very real role in my opinion, in my perspective, of being authentic with who he is and what he values. (Aria).

A few participants mentioned the company’s attempts to use internal and external social media platforms to engage employees. However, they did not believe these platforms were effective because “those platforms that contend to be one-way communication, even though there’s commenting features and things like that.” (Sybil). On social media, leaders’ engagement and communication also plays a key role in facilitating dialogue with employees. One participant stated:

Being able to engage our executives and our directors to be more vocal on social platforms will also promote more engagement as well. So, we’re trying to encourage them to actually engage on our employee-based LinkedIn posts, Facebook posts, and Instagram posts. Whatever it is, we’re seeing that there’s a lot more engagement when they know that their executives or their director are actually on their same platforms and they’re watching too. (Daisy).

Based on the participants’ descriptions of their practices,

communication with employees resembled two-way communication rather than dialogic communication. Foremost, the main motive for communication with employees was to give them the confidence to advocate for the company or industry, which mostly benefited the company. Although employees seemed to be given many opportunities to interact with the company, these opportunities were only presented at organization-controlled events. It is worth noting that participants believed that leaders played a prominent role in engaging employees; however, it is not clear if the leaders engaged in dialogue with employees. Although one CEO's self-disclosure laid the groundwork for trust and trust was considered a precursor to dialogue (Ciszek, 2020; Kent & Theunissen, 2016), dialogue did not happen after self-disclosure.

4.9. The general public

Some participants referred to the general public as another stakeholder group. Here the general public is defined as Canadian adults who may not have a direct economic interest, stake, or affiliation in the O&G companies, but they can observe the actions of the companies through mediated communication. Many participants mentioned using a mediated approach such as social media to reach out to the general public to "manage our (company) presence." Interestingly, participants demonstrated two distinctive attitudes about the effectiveness of social media as a dialogic platform. Most of the senior participants did not believe social media was an effective dialogic tool: "People don't engage with oil and gas companies that effectively on Facebook" (Henry). They regarded social media as a tool to showcase the company or share information in one-way communication. One participant provided a useful analogy: "You build a website and you go on social media and your website is like the book and it has tons of information on it and then social media as well with snippets that point to chapters inside the book, and hopefully keep people's interest" (Charlie).

However, younger participants believed that social media had the potential for dialogic communication. One participant shared her perspective:

Facebook is a platform where people really like to voice their opinion... You see a lot of dialogue and almost arguments happening, which is really interesting; you learn a lot when you read those arguments... We see our left threads that encourage people to talk about things. It typically is brought on by project updates. So anytime we have a project update, we see a lot of engagement... So anything that is related back to government or project updates, we see a lot of engagement and arguments, I guess, from both sides, which is important. I think that's where my perspective is: those conversations are really important for people to see. (Everly).

Younger participants also indicated that active listening and responding are required for social media to be dialogic. The social media strategy should include audience analysis, audience segmentation, and message tailoring to differentiate audiences on different platforms.

Although participants mentioned that a mediated strategy was used to manage relationships with publics, some of them indicated that the ideal strategy to manage this relationship in a dialogic way was using an interpersonal approach. One participant noted that "social media is certainly a big part of helping to manage it, but it's not the only way. Face to face is probably the keyway to chat with these people and meet with them and help manage relationships" (Tom). Two other participants mentioned that employees should also be involved in this relationship management process: "We've got hundreds of employees whose jobs are to communicate with people face-to-face, and one-on-one, you know, not doing mass communications which, you know, really doesn't put a face on the company" (Charlie).

Two features of dialogue were partially demonstrated in the discussion about this group of stakeholders. Younger practitioners saw that social media enabled engagement and arguments, especially on

Facebook. Although engagement and arguments do not equal dialogue, at a minimal level, we consider arguments as a sign that organizations allow stakeholders to voice different opinions, demonstrating some empathy. Younger practitioners suggested that including active listening and responding also demonstrated commitment to dialogue to some extent.

To summarize, only a few dialogic features emerged when examining the professionals' daily practices. Mutuality, commitment, and empathy were the three features we identified, but only to some extent. Propinquity and risk were not mentioned. In reality, professionals only practiced what can be considered shallow dialogue (Davidson, 2016) in the dialogic ladder (Lane, 2020). The next section examines the perceived challenges.

4.10. Challenges to dialogic public relations

Previous studies have documented many practical challenges in implementing dialogic public relations in practice (Lane, 2018; Lane & Bartlett, 2016). Some challenges include organizational culture, time, pre-existing attitudes of dialogic parties, and practitioners' lack of education and training on dialogic communication. Scholars have also identified several negative spaces where dialogue cannot happen, such as the absence of trust or a lack of willingness to engage (Kent & Lane, 2021). Some of the negative spaces have been identified from the two themes emerged from the data as participants described their challenges.

4.11. Industrial challenges

The greatest challenge participants perceived was associated with the nature of this controversial industry. Participants indicated that the long history of malicious actions and disingenuous communication from the industry (Aronczyk & Espinoza, 2021) led to a communication environment with negative spaces (Kent & Lane, 2021), which prevented dialogue from occurring. In this environment, there was little to no trust, and the distrust was mutual. One participant described the distrust from stakeholders, "There's a lot of suspicion and negativity around the industry" (Ivy). Companies also did not trust stakeholders, so some companies cut off communication. One participant stated, "The energy industry is reluctant to engage because there is the risk that the trolls will attack; then you'll post something, and they'll pounce on it" (Richard). This two-way distrust heavily impeded the possibility of dialogue between the O&G industry and their publics, thus creating a negative space for dialogue.

Another negative space in this environment is relevant to respect, which cannot occur without trust (Kent & Lane, 2021). Several participants expressed their feelings about stakeholders behaving in "strange" ways (Kent & Lane, 2021). Many participants mentioned that their communication, especially online communication, was always "attacked" by publics due to the controversial nature of the industry, making it difficult to have a "calm dialogue." Participants further explained that because of this hostile environment, communication from the company was easily "misunderstood." One participant explained, "People who are standing against the energy companies are very vocal... It's a huge challenge... Anytime you're communicating, the intent of your message doesn't get across successfully; it is taken the wrong way" (Richard). As a result, this turbulent environment has scared companies away from communication efforts in terms of dialogic communication and even simple engagement efforts.

Despite these challenges, participants acknowledged that the turbulent environment should not discourage O&G companies from engaging in dialogic communication because "there's a risk in not being there (communicating)." One participant stated,

There're people who are going to agree with you; there're people who are gonna misunderstand you; there're people who are gonna

disagree with you. So, I think the risk cannot deter us from doing the thing (communication). I think we cannot, because there's risk associated in communications and public relations activities...That can't be the reason why we don't do it. (Edith).

In this statement, the participant highlighted the demanding environment in which the O & G public relations functions, urging colleagues to tackle these challenges.

In addition, participants also believed that challenges can be overcome with learning from past experiences and encouraged practitioners to keep trying. One participant shared her story,

People (employees) were upset with how it (a connecting session) was done. And then when we did the first one remotely, people felt a little bit more comfortable with it. And then we did a second one remote, and again it was a lot of backlash from it, so it's really just trying to understand our stakeholders and what their needs are when we communicate that message. (Daisy).

In this example, the participant described the team's ongoing learning journey, drawing lessons from past events. Despite less-than-optimal outcomes, the team kept learning and trying to adapt.

4.12. Resource challenges

There were also resource challenges. Practitioners expressed frustration about not having enough people to pay close attention to different communication channels to show presence and engage with stakeholders. Having enough personnel may be a requirement for building dialogue. Lack of engagement is salient in social media and online channel management, particularly in some small to medium-sized companies. One participant from a small company explained, "Especially when it comes to social media, and the website...I think that that's just a lack of resources...They didn't have someone updating things on the website...or were willing to put money towards that. So, very rudimentary." (Nora). Companies' lack of resources may also stem from an underestimation of the value of communication, as one participant stated: "They (management) looked at it from a traditional standpoint, and anything beyond that, they didn't see the value in adding (communication)" (Herbert).

Resource challenges were also associated with the bureaucracy within the organizations' decision-making chain, especially for large companies. "There's a lot of different approval levels as well. Anytime there's an external story. Anytime any announcement goes up on our social channels" (Aria). There is no simple solution to overcome this type of challenge, as bureaucratic structures are commonly perceived as a barrier to public relations practices (O'Neil, 2003; Sen, 2022). However, one participant shared a story about how the evaluation of public relations activities can reduce resource challenges. She explained that the annual reputation study of her company proved the value of communication and after that reputation study: "I don't have to fight very hard for my communication budget, so that's good" (Mary).

5. Discussion

The dialogic theory has developed into a significant paradigm in public relations research over the last two decades (Zhou & Xu, 2022). However, scholars have voiced concerns that the theory is too utopian to be applied to everyday public relations activities (Kent & Lane, 2021; Lane, 2020). In addition, contemporary research has seldom examined how the tensions in contentious environments could affect dialogic initiatives, particularly from practitioners' perspectives. The O&G industry in Canada offers an unusual and significant framework for examining dialogic communication. Our study is an early attempt to contextualize dialogic public relations in the O&G industry, where the controversial nature of the business, public pressure, and communicators' moral obligations complicate dialogic strategies. Our findings add a

nuanced understanding of dialogic communication and offer insights into developing dialogic theory of public relations and strategies in the context of controversial businesses.

Our findings, in general, suggest partial alignment between practitioners' understanding of dialogic public relations and the related theoretical orientation. Specifically, the findings reveal that participants highlighted two-way communication, hearing multiple viewpoints, and transparency as critical characteristics of dialogic public relations in the O&G industry. These characteristics somewhat match the dialogic features of mutuality, empathy, and commitment (Kent & Taylor, 2002). It should be noted that this partial alignment implies that practitioners do not understand what true dialogue is, which supports the findings of previous studies (Lane, 2018; Lane & Barlett, 2016). Although practitioners' perceptions of the construct were more typical of shallow dialogue (D-I-N-O) at the lower rung of the dialogic ladder, it is noteworthy that shallow dialogue (D-I-N-O) is the precursor of true dialogue at the highest rung. Thus, there is a possibility that true dialogue can be realized (Lane, 2020).

Features of propinquity and risk were not mentioned as part of practitioners' understanding or practice of dialogic communication. This omission reveals a divergence between the concept of true dialogue and reality. Practitioners even perceived risk as a factor that impeded their communication with stakeholders. This observation indicates the contextual complexity of public relations practitioners' motives to initiate dialogic communication. Based on participants' unwillingness to engage in true dialogue due to possible conflicts arising from the nature of the business, a practical modification of dialogic principles should be made to ensure that the organizations do not sacrifice their bottom line (or benefits) as they pursue true dialogue. One way to balance the interests of both the organization and stakeholders may be using a Bakhtinian approach. This approach emphasizes the importance of multilateral conversations with different stakeholders and multiple interpretations evolving from open conversations (Capizzo, 2018). Open and transparent dialogue is realistic for controversial businesses such as O&G or other extractive industries, even at the risk of conflicts because not all stakeholders are the same. They may have diverse perspectives of the industry, and the companies are critical contributors to publics' knowledge and perceptions. As Capizzo (2018) suggested, public relations should help companies understand the complex layers of meaning in society and guide companies to add meaning and value to the public discourse. However, adopting the Bakhtinian approach might face challenges in industries with inherent stigmatization. Practitioners need to pursue higher professional ethical standards and enact their personal responsibility in valuing pluralist stakeholder engagement, organizational transparency, and public interests (Aronczyk & Espinoza, 2021; Vollero et al., 2019).

When the companies implemented dialogic strategies, they used interpersonal, mediated, and procedural dialogic efforts (Kent & Taylor, 2002) with different stakeholder groups. Specifically, in-person, informal dialogue was mostly initiated with community stakeholders. Formal and informal regular in-person meetings were also used to facilitate dialogue with investors. Mediated platforms were often used to communicate with the general public, but O&G companies have not viewed the general public as a typical stakeholder in previous studies (Chowdhury et al., 2018; Kirat, 2015). Our finding echoes Kruckeberg and Vujnovic's (2010) argument that *the public* is important in contemporary public relations practice. They suggested that modern information-sharing and communication technologies have given the general public the power to impose direct consequences on organizations. In an increasingly mediated society, the traditional understanding of strategic publics may not fully capture the diversity and breath of the audience of an organization's public relations practices. Thus, it is necessary to develop a more inclusive understanding of *the public* who "can act unpredictably and seemly chaotically" (Kruckeberg & Vujnovic, 2010, p.124). By fostering a more inclusive understanding of the public, the dialogic theory can be expanded by incorporating the unpredictable

and dynamic nature of the public in today's rapidly changing environment, allowing for more public-centred dialogic communication, aiming for relationship development and maintenance.

Although companies engaged in diverse efforts, none of the examples demonstrated all five features of true dialogic, and no single feature consistently emerged, which aligns with previous studies (Lane, 2018; Lane & Bartlett, 2016). Among the three strategies participants described, an interpersonal strategy was used most often, and this strategy demonstrated the most features of true dialogue. This result reflects the notion that dialogue is a concept that is deeply rooted in interpersonal communication (Pearson, 1989). Thus, we argue that interpersonal communication could still be the most ideal context for dialogic communication despite the prevalence of social media use in public relations. Mutuality, commitment, and empathy were sporadically demonstrated in the examples practitioners shared, indicating that the practice of shallow dialogue or D-I-N-O is prevalent in reality. The tailored strategies used with different stakeholders revealed that the O&G industry uses instrumental dialogue with targeted stakeholders. Some of the strategies had a clear agenda (e.g., educate the publics, encourage investment) rather than building relationships. This type of communication falls into the negative space of dialogue where communication is instrumental (Kent & Lane, 2021), diminishing the potential for dialogic communication.

Interestingly, there was a generational gap in participants' contrasting opinions regarding the value of using social media as a dialogue channel, which sheds light on the debate around the possibility or impossibility of dialogic communication on social media (Kent & Theunissen, 2016; Zhou & Xu, 2021). While the senior practitioners were skeptical about the effectiveness of social media in creating meaningful conversations with publics, the younger practitioners were more optimistic and forward-looking. Although senior practitioners acknowledged the importance and value of communication on social media in strengthening relationships with publics and rebuilding the industry's image, they were reluctant to engage publics through social media because they were suspicious of the public's willingness to listen and participate in the nonbiased dialogue. In contrast, younger practitioners suggested that social media can build meaningful dialogue, and they held a positive view of dialogue on social media. This difference could be because younger practitioners are digital natives (Milkman, 2017). More importantly, younger practitioners emphasized that social media dialogic communication is possible through active listening, targeted message design, and prompt responses. Instead of debating whether social media can be used for dialogue, their view emphasizes how to use social media and points to what practitioners can do to facilitate dialogic communication on social media. Practitioners cannot change the design of social media (e.g., restriction of 280 characters on Twitter) but can change how social media is used in practice. This generational difference has not been explored much in previous literature, and we suggest further investigating this finding in future studies.

The findings also reveal that dialogue is issue-based, constantly changing, and sensitive to public pressure (Chen et al., 2020), making planned dialogic behavior necessary for the O&G industry. Notably, several participants expressed their frustration with their companies' communication efforts being underappreciated due to the industry's social stigma, reflecting the practitioners' distrust of their interlocutors. In addition, although the participants held high moral standards for dialogic communication, hostile public opinions due to distrust in the industry, misinformation, crisis history, and bureaucracy largely constrained their dialogic practices. These are important barriers to pursuing true dialogue for controversial businesses such as O&G.

In summary, features of true dialogue only occurred sporadically in practitioners' perceptions and practices. No true dialogue (i.e., communication demonstrating all five features) emerged in the data, indicating that both the perceptions and practices of practitioners are at the lower rung of the dialogic ladder: shallow dialogue (D-I-N-O) (Lane, 2020). Our findings yield several important theoretical and practical

implications regarding the development of dialogic public relations scholarship and practice.

5.1. Theoretical implications

Our findings provide important implications for public relations scholars, practitioners, and controversial businesses, especially the O&G industry. Our study contributes to the literature in the context of applied dialogue and the potential for true dialogue in high-conflict contexts. Industries such as the O&G industry experience unique challenges, such as industry stigma and negative public sentiment, shaping practitioners' dialogic communications with key publics. Our results contribute to the literature by recognizing the inherent tensions and limitations in true dialogue when applied to an uncommon communication context, hence impeding the thorough application of dialogic principles (Huang & Yang, 2015; Kent & Taylor, 2002; Lane & Bartlett, 2016).

The interviews with communicators working in the O&G industry demonstrated their practice of shallow dialogue (Davidson, 2015), which is the precursor of true dialogue (Lane, 2020). Thus, there is a possibility that true dialogue can be realized. However, based on the intense industrial challenges participants discussed, we argue that a new approach—an industrial-level approach—should be developed in addition to the existing three approaches (Kent & Taylor, 2002) to dialogic communication when considering incorporating dialogue into public relations in a controversial industry. The participants emphasized various problems associated with the O&G industry challenging their daily communication with publics, including the stigma of the industry, a hostile communication environment towards the whole industry, and misconduct of peers in the same industry. To overcome these challenges, the whole industry needs to work together. Legitimacy theory argues that a company's legitimacy in a controversial industry is formed by how other institutions in the same environment act (O'Connor et al., 2017; Yang & Ji, 2019). Following this logic, public relations practices of companies in the same (controversial) industry can impact the overall communication environment and sentiment towards the industry, thus facilitating or hindering other companies' dialogic efforts and results. Hence, strategies used in individual organizations are not sufficient. Instead, an industrial-level approach to dialogue is recommended. This approach may need to be initiated by industrial associations. For instance, at a conference held by the industrial association, the concept and principles of dialogic communication can be introduced with practical examples to educate the entire industry. However, it should be noted that although the entire industry can work toward a genuinely dialogic approach, this approach also can be exploited by the industry to manipulate various stakeholders into accepting their actions as legitimate (Aronczyk & Espinoza, 2021).

Second, this study extends the scope of the dialogic theory of public relations by utilizing a new theoretical framework for analyzing professional practice: the dialogic ladder (Lane, 2020). The dialogic ladder captures the delicate relations and tensions of various conflicting concepts relevant to dialogue in public relations, enabling us to connect a highly normative theory (Kent & Taylor, 2002) to professional practice. As the results suggest, although true dialogue was not observed in practitioners' perceptions or practices, the dialogic ladder allows us to observe the precursors of true dialogue. Shallow dialogue (D-I-N-O) may signal the possibility of achieving true dialogue (Lane, 2020) in practice. By utilizing the theoretical framework of the dialogic ladder, our study provides empirical evidence of both shallow dialogue and D-I-N-O. It presents the delicate relations and tension of these two forms of communication and dialogue from practitioners' perspectives. Specifically, our results reveal that the concept of D-I-N-O is a practical one in the context of the O&G industry. Our findings showed elements of two-way communication, interaction, responses, and some characteristics of the five features of true dialogue.

Third, our study enriches the understanding of the five features of true dialogue (Kent & Taylor, 2002) in practice. The results from

previous studies (Lane, 2018; Lane & Barlett, 2016) along with our results, demonstrate the prominence of the mutuality feature in practice. This feature was most evident in the professionals' examples of practice. The last evidence was of the risk feature, and practitioners tended to avoid it in practice, which echoes previous findings (Lane, 2018). Based on these findings, we argue that the nuances of the five features of true dialogue (Kent & Taylor, 2002) need to be examined further to understand how they are related. There may be a progressive relationship among these features, with mutuality being the most easily achieved and an antecedent feature to other features.

Lastly, this study provides empirical evidence for negative dialogic spaces (Kent & Lane, 2021). Negative spaces that emerged from the data are where there is no trust, where there is no respect, and where communication is instrumental, and participants described them as the challenges to achieving true dialogic communication. Therefore, we argue that negative spaces could be combined with the dialogic ladder concept to create a more comprehensive theoretical framework to understand dialogic public relations. In this framework, the dialogic ladder would be placed in an environment where negative spaces exist and impede the realization of true dialogue.

5.2. Practical implications

The empirical evidence of our study also offers practical implications. First, a contingent approach to dialogic communication is recommended by tailoring dialogic practices based on different publics' needs and preferences to maximize relationship-building opportunities. Practitioners should be aware of the challenges the industry faces and consider incorporating dialogic communication features depending on specific situations/stakeholders and communication contexts. Second, because of the knowledge gap related to dialogic communication between the industry and practitioners, practitioners need to work together to proactively educate the industry about the value of dialogic communication to facilitate the practices. One promising approach is through research/evaluation. One of the participants indicated that after seeing the value of communication through an annual evaluation, the company was willing to invest more in public relations. If practitioners can use research or evaluation to demonstrate the positive outcomes of dialogic communication, the industry may be more prone to this dialogic approach. Participants also acknowledged that their leaders played a key role in facilitating such dialogue with both external and internal stakeholders. Thus, it would be more effective to include leaders in this educational effort.

In addition, both practitioners and companies should be mentally prepared for the possible negative results (e.g., criticism) of their dialogic efforts due to the controversial nature of the industry. The participants recommended that practitioners should not be discouraged because of undesirable outcomes, but they may want to learn from past experiences to improve the next dialogic strategy.

5.3. Limitations and future directions

This study has several limitations that should be addressed. First, our sample is limited to O&G companies in Canada. This industry is unique in that it operates globally, and dialogic public relations vary depending on economic, regulatory, and cultural variances. Future research could expand the sample to other locations and generate more generalizable and comparable insights about the O&G industry's dialogic public relations. Second, this study only focuses on the organizational perspective of dialogic efforts, which may be limited to the functionalist view without fully recognizing how stakeholders (e.g., local communities) react to such dialogic initiatives. True dialogue highlights both meaning-making and co-creation (Taylor & Kent, 2014). Thus, future research should further explore how important stakeholders, as identified by the O&G industry in our study, evaluate the dialogic efforts of companies in terms of dialogic principles and approaches. Additional studies on

publics' perspectives would also reveal the effects of dialogue to answer the "so what?" question. Thirdly, our study did not include significant exploration or discussion on the industry's interaction with (environmental) activist groups. However, the contestation between activists and O&G companies is worthy of further analysis using dialogue and activism frameworks (Ganesh & Zoller, 2012). In addition, our findings on generational differences in practitioners' perception of social media as a dialogic tool are noteworthy and warrant further investigation. We suggest future research using survey techniques to further identify the generational difference in professional usage of social media in the O&G industry. Fifth, our results indicated that practitioners organized their strategies based on different stakeholder groups and described strategically tailored strategies. Considering the tension between the O&G industry's efforts to avoid public scrutiny and the concept of genuine dialogue, future studies may explore whether genuine dialogue can be strategically developed. Lastly, although we presented the definition of true dialogue (i.e., the highest rung of the communication ladder) to participants, they were not explicitly instructed to follow this definition during the interviews. Considering the practitioners' lack of education and training in dialogic communication (Lane & Barlett, 2016), future studies should explicitly explain the relevant concepts or even hold a training session to help them understand the relevant concepts and to gain insights from the training before the interviews. By doing so, we believe social desirability bias can also be reduced.

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Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability

The authors do not have permission to share data.

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